



Celestine Broussard, local artist, dies at 34

By Alexandra Richard

Celestine Helene Broussard, 34, entered into eternal rest on Feb. 16. Broussard was a native of Beau Marais in Iberia Parish and a long-time resident of New Orleans. She is survived by her mother, Lune-Marie Broussard, and siblings Athalie and Pascal.

Broussard was a painter, community organizer and social activist. However, she is best known to many New Orleanians as one of the founders of the beloved Carnival krewe the Mystic Krewe of Marie Laveau. Broussard's love of Mardi Gras stretched back to her childhood, when she was chosen as the Princess of the Krewe of Rougarou in Beau Marais.

A few years later, it was her high school teacher, Virginie Boone, who first noticed Broussard's talent for visual arts and recommended she study painting at a summer arts program in New Orleans. Coming into contact with the rich culture of New Orleans electrified Broussard and changed her life forever. Returning to Beau Marais for six short months, she worked two part-time jobs while attending high school so she could return to the Crescent City in the fall as a permanent student. Naturally, she accomplished this, as those who knew Broussard say she accomplished anything she put her mind to.

While earning her Bachelor of Fine Arts from the Sauvignon College of Visual Art, Broussard rented a house on Royal Street with filmmaker Ines Couvillion and tattoo artist Sylvia Jones, establishing a friendship that would last long beyond

three would become famous for their raucous parties, art happenings and, ultimately, for forming the all-female Mystic Krewe of Marie Laveau. During their inaugural parade, Broussard's portrayal of Laveau — complete with a live snake acting as Laveau's pet boa constrictor, Zombi — was the talk of New Orleans. Broussard's enduring Mardi Gras legacy can be seen in her mentoring of younger krewes, particularly the Krewe of the Pirate Brothers Jean and Pierre, and in the Three Kings Ball, a cross-krewe party raising money for Broussard's nonprofit, NOLA KidsArt.

As Marie Laveau's captain, Broussard's artistic vision gained a wider audience, and she was hired to paint murals ranging from local businesses to municipally-backed beautification projects. Her first high-profile commission came from fellow Carnival reveler and mentor, Cyril Fortier, who hired Broussard to create a two-story mural for Fortier Foods' corporate headquarters. This collaboration was the start of a fruitful partnership, and Broussard's art can still be seen on Fortier's carry-out bags, boxes and cups across Louisiana.

Still, despite her commercial success, Broussard's greatest impact will always be her legacy of fearless activism. From her large-scale public works, such as her mural commemorating Oretha Castle Haley, to her stalwart presence at protests and city council meetings, Broussard had a keen eye for identifying moral injustice and the conviction that the world could be a better and more equal place if we choose to fight for it.

It is truly a deep loss to the cultural fabric of our city to lose one so bright at so young an age. Broussard will live on through her work and its influence on the next wave of young artists in New Orleans.

The funeral service will be held at St. John the Evangelist in Beau Marais on Feb. 25 at noon. A second line is scheduled in the Bywater for March 4 at 4 p.m. Those who wish to honor Broussard's memory may send contributions to NOLA KidsArt. The organization is currently seeking funding for a permanent facility to house its classes and programs.

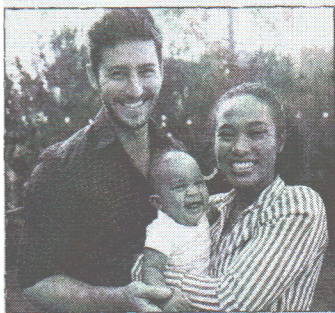


Velma Arianna Lewis and Daniel John McSorley were married on New Year's Eve at St. Louis Cathedral. The Very Reverend Ian Bailey officiated.

The bride, 27, will be known as Velma McSorley. She is a graduate of Our Lady of Mercy Academy and Aitchafalaya State University. She currently works as

office manager at Pelican Dental Center in Metairie. She is the daughter of Ty and Alethea Lewis of Mandeville.

The bridegroom, 32, is a graduate of Algiers Charter School and is the co-owner of Blue Bayou Construction. He is the son of Sarah McSorley of New Orleans.



Mr. Christopher West and Mr. Kyle Reischauer announce the engagement of their daughter, Ms. Blake West-Reischauer to Robert Garcia of Chicago. The bride-elect is currently performing her residency in pediatrics at Presbyterian Hospital, where the bridegroom works as an occupational therapist. The couple plan to have a destination wedding in Belize this fall.

Ms. Lydia Foret Dahl of Biloxi, Miss. along with Mr. Richard Dahl and Dr. Alicia Bates Dahl of New Orleans, announce the engagement of their daughter, Ms. Olivia Dahl, to Mr. Patrick Foster. The couple plan to marry next spring in Gulf Shores, Ala.



Roger and Carol Zhou of Covington celebrated their 50th wedding anniversary on Sunday. In celebration of this milestone, a garden party was given in their honor by their son-in-law and

